

OVERVIEW

This guide documents the full end-to-end deployment of Windows Server 2022 as a virtual machine on VMware ESXi 8.0 U2. It covers VM creation via the ESXi web client, OS installation from an ISO image stored in the ESXi datastore, and post-installation configuration including network setup and hostname assignment.

Prerequisites

ESXi Host	VMware ESXi 8.0 U2 or later
Datastore Free Space	Minimum 60 GB
Windows Server 2022 ISO	SERVER_EVAL_x64FRE_en-us.iso (4.7 GB) in the ISO datastore folder
vCPU / RAM	4 vCPUs / 16 GB RAM (adjust per workload)
Disk	40 GB thin-provisioned VMDK
Network	Virtual switch and port group configured on ESXi host
Browser	Modern browser with access to ESXi web client

PART 1 — Create the Virtual Machine in ESXi

Step 1.1 — Launch the New VM Wizard

Log in to the ESXi web client at <https://<your-esxi-ip>/ui>. Navigate to **Virtual Machines** in the left sidebar and click **Create / Register VM**. Select **Create a new virtual machine** and click **Next**.

Step 1.2 — Name the VM and Select Guest OS

Configure the VM identity and operating system type as shown below:

VM Name	SolarWinds VM (customise to your preference)
Compatibility	ESXi 8.0 U2 virtual machine
Guest OS Family	Windows
Guest OS Version	Microsoft Windows Server 2022 (64-bit)

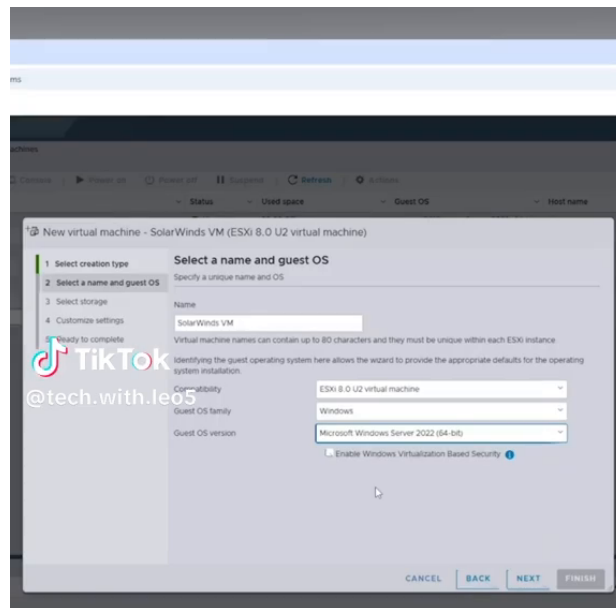


Figure 1 — VM Name & Guest OS configuration

NOTE: Enable Windows Virtualization Based Security is optional for lab environments. For production deployments, consider enabling it for enhanced kernel-level protection.

Step 1.3 — Select Storage

Select the target datastore (e.g., **datastore1**) and click **Next**. Ensure the datastore has sufficient free space for the VM disk and any snapshots.

Step 1.4 — Customize VM Hardware

vCPUs	4
Memory	16 GB
Hard Disk 1	40 GB (thin provisioned on SATA controller)
SCSI Controller	VMware Paravirtual
SATA Controller	New SATA controller
Network Adapter 1	vcentertnetwork — VMXNET 3
CD/DVD Drive	Datastore ISO — SERVER_EVAL_x64FRE_en-us.iso

To attach the Windows Server 2022 ISO, under CD/DVD Drive select **Datastore ISO file** and click **Browse**. Navigate to the **ISO** folder in the Datastore browser:

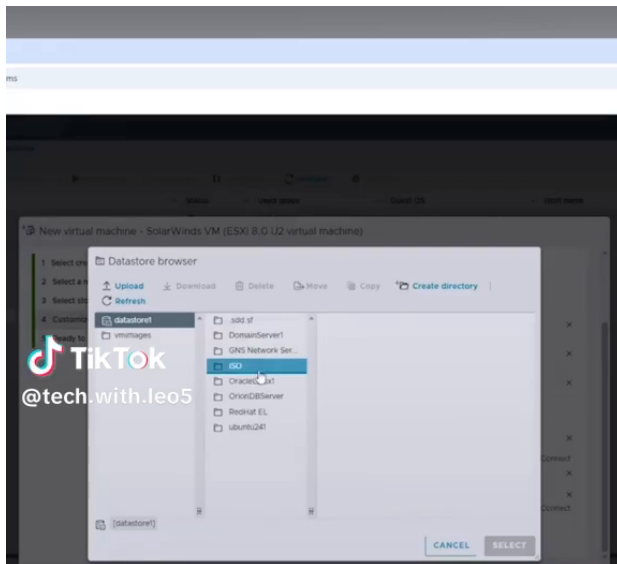


Figure 2 — ISO Folder in Datastore Browser

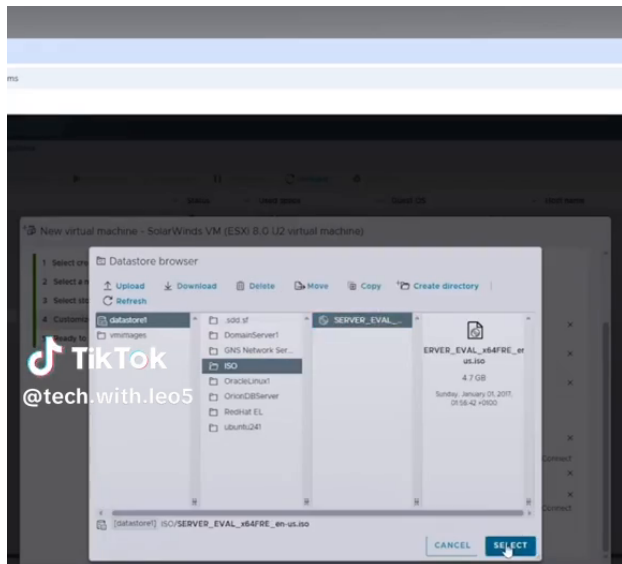


Figure 3 — ISO File Selected

Step 1.5 — Review and Finish

The **Ready to Complete** screen summarises all VM settings before creation. Verify all values are correct, then click **Finish**.

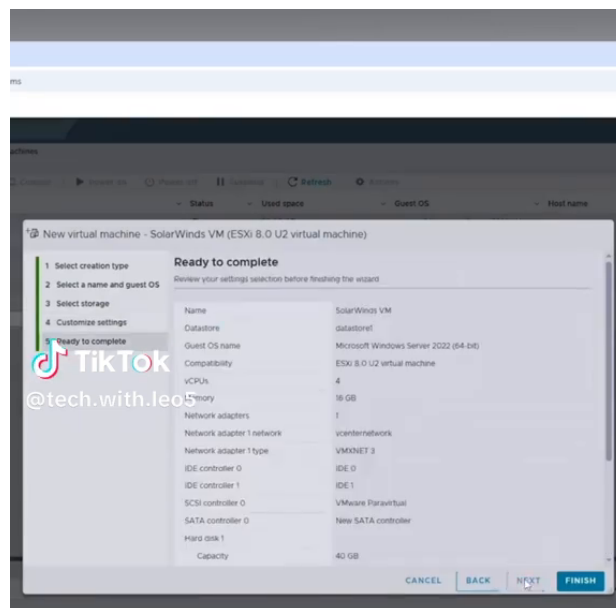


Figure 4 — Ready to Complete Summary

PART 2 — Install Windows Server 2022

Step 2.1 — Power On and Boot to ISO

From the Virtual Machines list, select the VM and click **Power On**. Open the VM console. The VM boots from the attached ISO and loads the Windows Server Setup wizard.

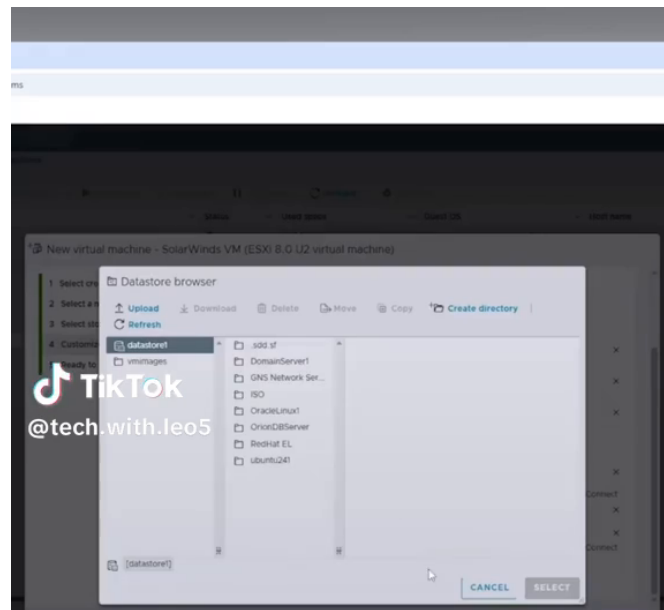


Figure 5 — VM Console: Datastore Browser during ISO Mount

Step 2.2 — Accept the License Agreement

When the license terms screen appears, read the Microsoft Software License Terms, check **"I accept the Microsoft Software License Terms"**, and click **Next**.



Figure 6 — License Agreement Screen

Step 2.3 — Select Installation Drive

On the drive selection screen, select **Drive 0 Unallocated Space (40 GB)** and click **Next**. Windows will automatically partition the drive.

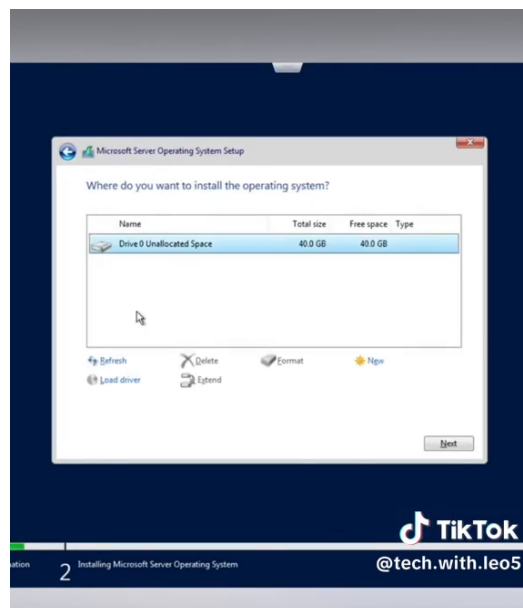


Figure 7 — Drive Selection (40 GB Unallocated)

NOTE: For a clean lab installation, selecting unallocated space and clicking Next is sufficient. Use New / Format / Delete for custom partition layouts.

Step 2.4 — Installation Progress and First Reboot

Windows Server 2022 copies files and installs automatically. This typically takes 5–15 minutes depending on host performance. The VM reboots automatically.

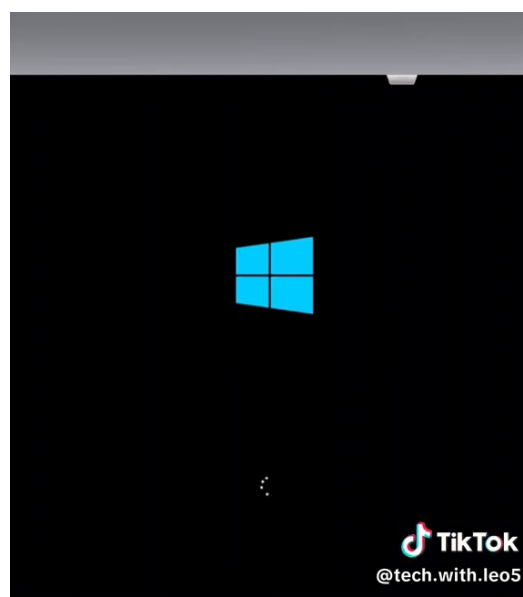


Figure 8 — Windows Boot Logo (Post-Install First Boot)

Step 2.5 — Set Administrator Password

After the first boot, set a password for the built-in **Administrator** account. Use a strong password (minimum 8 characters, mixed case, numbers, symbols). Click **Finish** to complete initial setup.

Step 2.6 — Windows Server Lock Screen

Once setup completes, the Windows Server 2022 lock screen confirms the OS is running. Press **Ctrl+Alt+Delete** (use the "Send Ctrl+Alt+Del" button in the VM console) to unlock and log in.

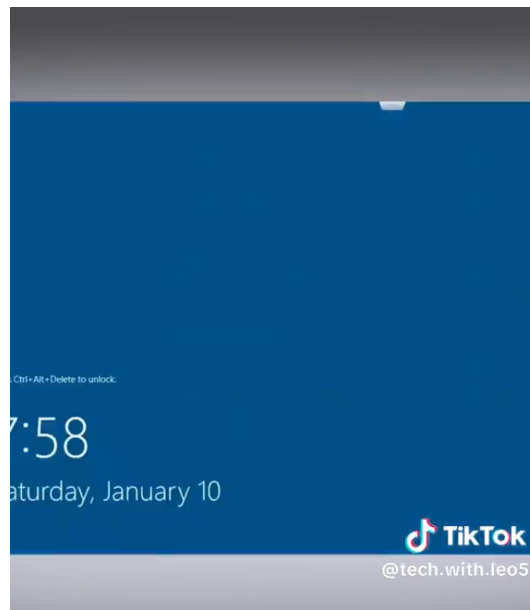


Figure 9 — Windows Server 2022 Lock Screen

Step 2.7 — Windows Server Desktop

A successful login confirms the deployment. The desktop watermark displays the edition, build number, and remaining evaluation period.

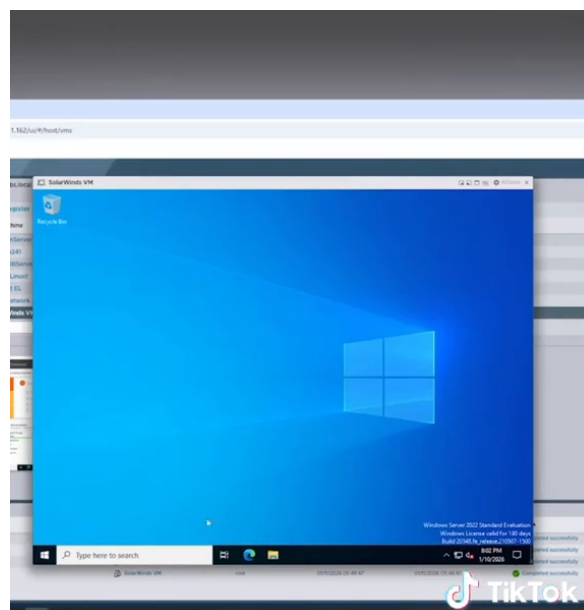


Figure 10 — Windows Server 2022 Desktop (Deployment Confirmed)

PART 3 — Post-Installation Configuration

Step 3.1 — Configure Network (TCP/IPv4)

Open **Network and Internet Settings**, click **Change adapter options**, right-click **Ethernet0** and select **Properties**. Then select **Internet Protocol Version 4 (TCP/IPv4)** and click **Properties**.

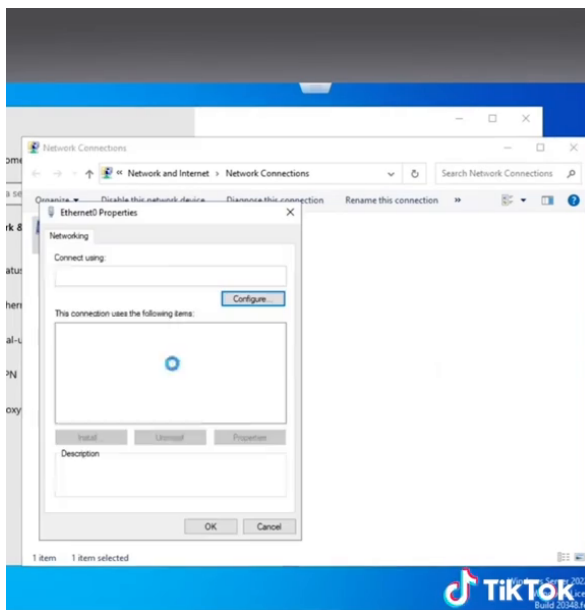


Figure 11 — Ethernet0 Properties

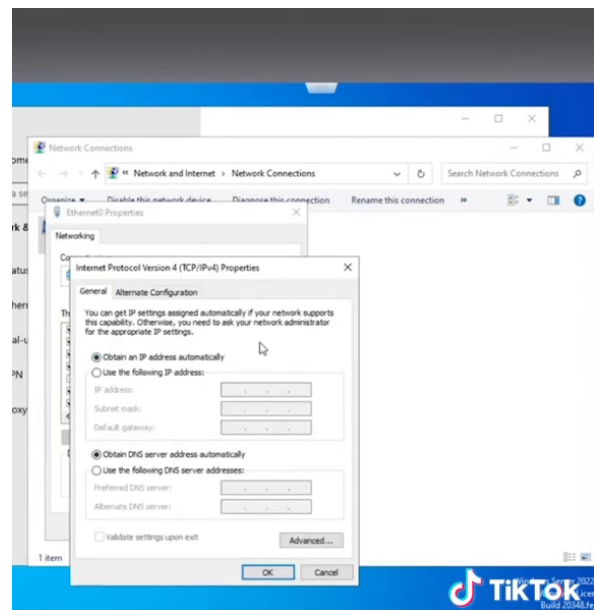


Figure 12 — TCP/IPv4 Properties

DHCP (Lab Default)	Select "Obtain an IP address automatically" and "Obtain DNS server address automatically"
Static IP (Recommended for Servers)	Select "Use the following IP address" — enter IP, Subnet Mask, Default Gateway, and DNS servers

Step 3.2 — Windows Server Management Tools

Right-clicking the Start button provides quick access to all key Windows Server management tools, including Server Manager, PowerShell, Device Manager, Disk Management, Event Viewer, and Task Manager.

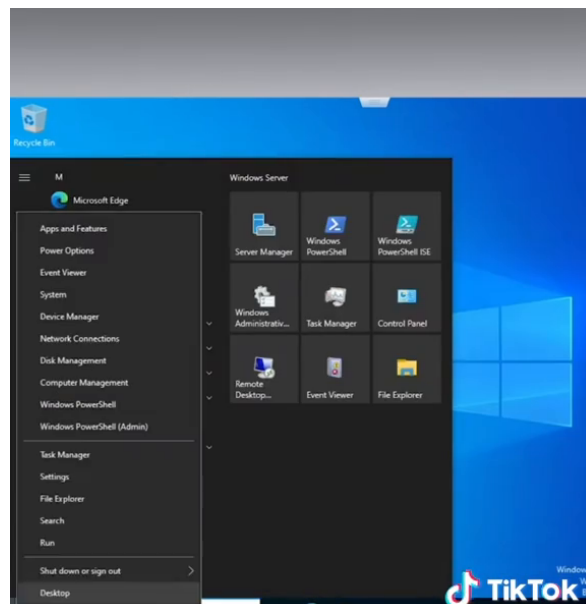


Figure 13 — Windows Server Start Menu with Server Management Tools

Step 3.3 — Rename the Server

Assigning a meaningful hostname is essential before joining a domain or deploying services. Go to **Settings > System > About** and click **Rename this PC**. Enter the desired hostname and restart.

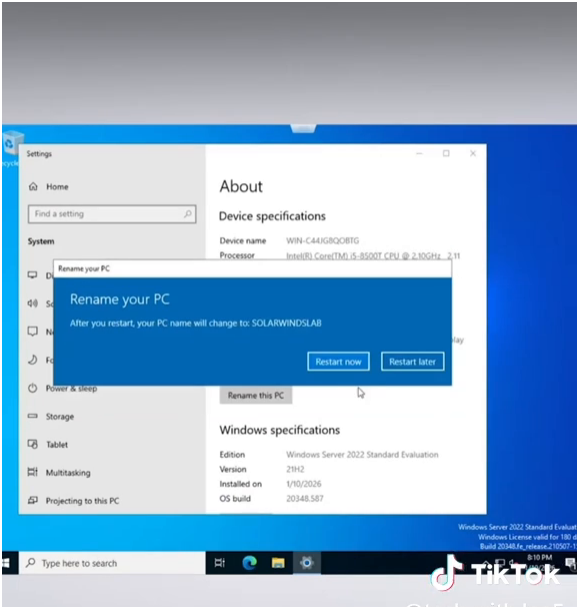


Figure 14 — Renaming the Server to SOLARWINDSLAB

Device Name (Before)	WIN-C44JG8Q0BTG
New Hostname	SOLARWINDSLAB
Processor	Intel(R) Core(TM) i5-8500T @ 2.10 GHz
Edition	Windows Server 2022 Standard Evaluation
Version	21H2
OS Build	20348.587
Installed On	1/10/2026
License	Valid for 180 days (Evaluation)

PART 4 — Final Verification

After renaming and rebooting, log back in to confirm the full deployment. The ESXi console title bar shows the correct VM name, and the desktop watermark confirms the OS edition and build.

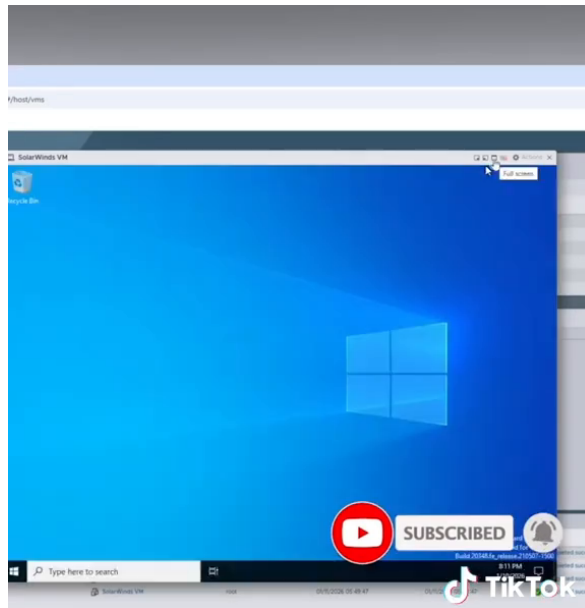


Figure 15 — Deployment Complete: Windows Server 2022 Running in ESXi

DEPLOYMENT CHECKLIST

Step 1	Create VM in ESXi (name, guest OS, storage, hardware settings)	DONE
Step 2	Attach Windows Server 2022 ISO from datastore ISO folder	DONE
Step 3	Power on VM and launch Windows Server Setup wizard	DONE
Step 4	Accept Microsoft Software License Agreement	DONE
Step 5	Select installation drive (Drive 0 — 40 GB unallocated)	DONE
Step 6	Complete installation and set Administrator password	DONE
Step 7	Log in to Windows Server 2022 desktop	DONE
Step 8	Configure network adapter (DHCP or static IP)	DONE
Step 9	Rename server hostname (SOLARWINDSLAB)	DONE
Step 10	Verify OS edition, build number, and hardware specs	DONE

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEPS

- Install **VMware Tools** — improves performance and enables guest OS integration (clipboard, display resizing)
- Activate Windows — use a KMS server or enter a product key to activate beyond the 180-day evaluation period
- Enable **Remote Desktop (RDP)** — for remote management without the ESXi console
- Join an **Active Directory Domain** — if deploying in an enterprise or multi-server lab
- Add server roles via **Server Manager** — DNS, DHCP, IIS, AD DS, File Server, etc.
- Configure **Windows Firewall** — restrict inbound/outbound traffic as appropriate
- Set up **Windows Update** or a WSUS server for ongoing patching

- Take an ESXi **snapshot** before making major configuration changes

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